

e) Engages you in a candid conversation about what kind of food you'd like to eat and where you'd like to go. Together, you agree upon a budget for the evening, and that helps you narrow down your choice of restaurant. Ultimately, you decide to have a glass of wine and shrimp cocktail at an outdoor bistro before heading back to his place, where he treats you to a simple yet satisfying meal of grilled fish and Spanish rice. And the meal is so good, and everything so relaxed, that it's a great evening for both of you.

2. When you meet your partner's family for the first time, you wonder:

- a) Why they seem so guarded. They eat very little, and when the meal is over, they don't offer to pick up the tab. Several times, your partner starts to ask them a question and they bristle, as if they are expecting the worst.
- b) They treat you both to a fancy four-course meal, no holds barred. You appreciate the generosity, but you recognize the behavior—you've seen your partner make similarly lavish purchases he can't really afford. Aren't his parents retired high school teachers? From the way they're throwing around their credit card, you'd think they were plastic surgeons.
- c) How it is possible for parents to so blatantly spoil their adult child. Are they even aware that their son is, in fact, grown up? They coddle and dote on him as if he were still in kindergarten. They worry he isn't resting enough (but he sleeps all day long!) and they seem convinced he's the next Warhol. By the time you see your partner's father slip him a couple \$100 bills and say, "Keep on keepin' on, kiddo," you're seeing a future where he paints soup cans and you exist on them.